husband at the time he was assassinated; he'd died without ever returning to the White House. Next to the Lincoln bedroom, with an entrance opposite the grand staircase, was the Treaty Room, its walls lined with historic treaties and documents, including the Emancipation Proclamation. Off the great center hall of the family quarters, on the south side, was the formal living room, a thirty-by-forty-foot oval room opening onto the Truman Balcony.

Even though we were faced with having to get into formal dress for the evening's inaugural festivities, Nancy and I couldn't escape a feeling of unreality as we went from room to room.

Later, I peeked into the Oval Office as its official occupant for the first time. I felt a weight come down on my shoulders, and I said a prayer asking God's help in my new job.

That evening, we almost danced our feet off at ten different inaugural balls held all over the city of Washington. Then Nancy and I spent our first night in the White House.

The next day, the celebrating was over and it was down to work. I had come to Washington with my mind set on a program and I was anxious to get started on it.